Italian Present Tense (Il Presente Indicativo)

The present tense in Italian describes what is happening now, habits, and near-future plans. Italian verbs are grouped by their infinitive ending: -are, -ere, or -ire. To conjugate a regular verb, drop the ending to get the stem, then add the endings for each person: io, tu, lui/lei, noi, voi, loro.

Regular -are verbs

- Endings: -o, -i, -a, -iamo, -ate, -ano.
- Example: parlare (to speak) becomes parlo, parli, parla, parliamo, parlate, parlano.
- -are is the largest group of Italian verbs.

Regular -ere verbs

- Endings: -o, -i, -e, -iamo, -ete, -ono.
- Example: scrivere (to write) becomes scrivo, scrivi, scrive, scriviamo, scrivete, scrivono.

Regular -ire verbs

- Endings: -o, -i, -e, -iamo, -ite, -ono.
- Example: dormire (to sleep) becomes dormo, dormi, dorme, dormiamo, dormite, dormono.
- Some -ire verbs add -isc- in every form except noi and voi. Example: finire (to finish) becomes finisco, finisci, finisce, finiamo, finite, finiscono. Capire (to understand) follows the same pattern.

Spelling changes

- Verbs ending in -care and -gare add an h before -i to keep the hard sound. Example: cercare (to look for) gives tu cerchi and noi cerchiamo; pagare (to pay) gives tu paghi and noi paghiamo.
- Verbs ending in -iare keep only one i. Example: mangiare (to eat) gives tu mangi and noi mangiamo; studiare (to study) gives tu studi.

Two essential irregular verbs

- essere (to be): sono, sei, è, siamo, siete, sono. Note that io sono and loro sono are identical.
- avere (to have): ho, hai, ha, abbiamo, avete, hanno. The h is silent and only marks the difference from o (or), ai (to the), a (to) and anno (year).

Useful rules

- Subject pronouns are usually dropped, because the verb ending already shows the person. Parlo italiano means I speak Italian.
- The formal you, Lei, uses the lui/lei form of the verb. Lei parla inglese? means Do you speak English? when addressing someone formally.
- To make a sentence negative, put non directly before the verb. Non parlo tedesco means I do not speak German.

- The present tense can express the near future: Domani parto per Roma means I am leaving for Rome tomorrow.